TWO ENGLISH MUGS PODCAST

Think In English (Stop Translating)

Episode 29 · Full Transcription

Emma & Josh

B1 Intermediate

EMMA: Do you translate words in your head, but then the pause gets too long and you feel stuck?

JOSH: Uh, my mind turns into this, like, old rusty train.

EMMA: Oh no.

JOSH: Yeah, it just stops dead on the tracks. Steam comes out of my ears.

EMMA: Huh, I can clearly see the steam coming from your ears.

JOSH: It is bad. I try to find the coal to make the train move, but the fire is cold. The other person just stares at me.

EMMA: Well, we will fix that today.

JOSH: I hope so.

EMMA: We will. And later on, we will look at a weird step nobody expects.

JOSH: A weird step?

EMMA: Yes. It hits you right when you reach a flat patch, as you learn.

JOSH: A flat patch? I do not know about that. Is it really doable to stop that old train?

EMMA: It is.

JOSH: I mean, my brain loves its old habits. It wants to stay on those rusty tracks forever.

EMMA: It is very doable. Today we will learn how to think in English and stop the rusty train for good.

JOSH: Okay. I am ready.

EMMA: Hello and welcome to Two English Mugs, where we learn English through real everyday conversations. I'm Emma.

JOSH: And I'm Josh.

EMMA: We are so glad you are here to join us.

JOSH: We really are.

EMMA: This is a B1 lesson. That means it is not baby talk, you know?

JOSH: Right. But it is not too hard either. It sits right in the middle for you.

EMMA: Exactly. We will explain any new words as we go along today.

JOSH: Oh, and do not forget to grab your PDF transcript.

EMMA: Yes, for sure. And we also made a list of useful vocabulary words for you to study.

JOSH: You can find all of that in the description below.

EMMA: Now, um, let us just settle in.

JOSH: Yeah, take a breath.

EMMA: Maybe you are folding your clean shirts right now in your room.

JOSH: Oh, I hate folding shirts.

EMMA: Or maybe you are taking your dog for a nice slow walk in the park.

JOSH: Or maybe you are putting the trash bins out by the road. I always forget to do that on time.

EMMA: You do forget a lot, but wherever you are right now, just relax.

JOSH: Yes, please do.

EMMA: You do not have to answer us today. Just let the English wash over you.

JOSH: No stress at all. Just ride along with us and enjoy the sound.

EMMA: So let us flow right into our first big idea. I call this the round trip.

JOSH: The round trip. Like, uh, taking a long plane ride from your home and coming back again?

EMMA: Yes, exactly like that. Let us look at that huge, awful delay in a chat.

JOSH: Oh, I hate the delay.

EMMA: Right. Someone says a word to you, you hear it well, but then a vast, empty space of time passes before you speak.

JOSH: That empty space makes me sweat.

EMMA: I bet it does.

JOSH: I feel like the other person is judging me while I stand there in silence.

EMMA: They are probably just waiting, but I know the fear is real. That long delay happens because your brain is taking a round trip.

JOSH: What is the brain doing during this trip? Is it packing a suitcase?

EMMA: No suitcase. It takes 4 long steps to process the chat. Step 1 is simple. You hear the English phrase.

JOSH: Okay, step 1 is easy. My friend asks, how was your weekend? I hear the sounds clearly.

EMMA: But then we hit step 2. Your brain takes that English phrase and sends it all the way home.

JOSH: All the way home?

EMMA: Yes, you translate it into your home language.

JOSH: Right. So my brain says, ah, they want to know about my weekend, but it says it in my first language.

EMMA: Exactly.

JOSH: It feels safer that way.

EMMA: It feels safe, but it is a trap. Next is step 3. You have to form your reply.

JOSH: Okay.

EMMA: But you are still thinking in your home language.

JOSH: Oh, right. So I think I went to the park and ate a huge cake, but I build that thought using my native tongue.

EMMA: And finally, we reach step 4. This is the hardest step of all.

JOSH: What is it?

EMMA: You take that home language reply and you translate it back into English.

JOSH: Oh, wow. By the time I finish all 4 steps, my friend is staring at me.

EMMA: They are.

JOSH: They might wonder if I fell asleep standing up.

EMMA: I have been there. Hear, translate, answer, translate back. It is double the work for your mind.

JOSH: It is a very heavy load.

EMMA: It is.

JOSH: No wonder I get so tired when I speak for a long time.

EMMA: Exactly.

JOSH: My brain is carrying heavy rocks back and forth.

EMMA: It burns too much fuel. Your mind runs out of energy fast. So the lesson here is clear. The trip must be cut down to just 2 steps.

JOSH: Just 2?

EMMA: Yes. You hear and you speak.

JOSH: Only 2 steps. That sounds like a dream. But wait, if I skip the trip home, how do I know what they said?

EMMA: What do you mean?

JOSH: It feels like jumping without a net.

EMMA: You have to link the English word right to the pure idea. If I say apple, do not think of your home word for apple.

JOSH: What do I think of then?

EMMA: Think of the red fruit. See the shiny red skin in your mind. Taste the sweet juice.

JOSH: Oh, I see.

EMMA: Connect the English word to the real item.

JOSH: I just link apple to the picture of the fruit. I do not need my home language to tell me what an apple is.

EMMA: Exactly. You skip the middleman. You stay in the English zone the entire time.

- **JOSH:** I want to stay in that zone, but what happens if I know the word, but my mind just cannot find it fast enough.
- **EMMA:** That happens a lot. And this brings us to words on a shelf.
- **JOSH:** Words on a shelf? Like dusty old books in a tall library?
- **EMMA:** Yes, like that. Imagine you know a lot of words. You studied them for years.
- **JOSH:** Right. I have a big list in my head.
- **EMMA:** But you cannot reach them when you need them. They sit just out of reach.
- **JOSH:** I know that feeling so well. The shelf is way too high. I jump, but I cannot grab the book I want.
- **EMMA:** We all have those days. The words are sitting in your mind like books on a dusty shelf. You rarely take them down.
- **JOSH:** So how do I get them down? Do I need a ladder?
- **EMMA:** Haha, no ladder needed. We need to move those books down to a lower shelf.
- **JOSH:** How?
- **EMMA:** We do this by swapping words.
- **JOSH:** Swapping words? What does that mean? Like, uh, trading a toy with a friend?
- **EMMA:** A swap is when you trade one thing for a new thing. When you have a clear thought, force yourself to find 2 or 3 ways to say it.
- **JOSH:** So I do not rely on just one single word to save me.
- **EMMA:** Right. Let me give you a story from my own daily life. Just this morning, I was making my coffee.
- **JOSH:** A very vital part of any good morning. I need my coffee too.
- **EMMA:** For sure. I took a sip and it was quite bitter. I thought, I need more sugar.
- **JOSH:** A very basic thought. You wanted sugar. So what did you do?
- **EMMA:** I stopped right there in my kitchen. I pushed myself to find a new way to say it. I thought, this coffee is not sweet enough.
- **JOSH:** Oh, I like that swap. Not sweet enough. Same idea, new words.
- **EMMA:** Exactly.
- **JOSH:** It is like opening a second door to the same room.
- **EMMA:** Then I pushed for a third way. This needs to be sweeter.
- **JOSH:** 3 different paths to the exact same idea. That is so smart.
- **EMMA:** The lesson is to build multiple paths to an idea. If you do this, you will never get stuck searching for one perfect word.
- **JOSH:** But wait, what if my swap is a bit strange?

EMMA: Strange how?

JOSH: What if I choose a funny word and the other person laughs?

EMMA: A funny word is always better than silence.

JOSH: Really?

EMMA: Yes. If you stay quiet, the chat dies right there. If you say a funny word, you both might smile, but the chat lives on.

JOSH: That takes the fear away. The goal is just to keep the ball in the air.

EMMA: Yes. So here is a fun task for you to try this week. Pick 3 daily routines.

JOSH: Okay. Routines, things I do every single day without fail.

EMMA: Yes. Let us say breakfast, travel to work, and going to bed.

JOSH: Breakfast, travel, bed.

EMMA: 3 normal, easy parts of the day. During these times, look at what you are doing. If you are getting ready for bed, you might think, I am brushing my teeth.

JOSH: Right. I am brushing my teeth. A simple daily fact.

EMMA: Now find 2 more ways to say it right then. You could say, I am cleaning my teeth.

JOSH: Or I am scrubbing my teeth. Scrubbing, like rubbing very hard with a thick brush.

EMMA: Yes, scrubbing works. By doing this daily, you build a wide web of words. The shelf gets lower and lower.

JOSH: The books come down. They're so easy to grab when I am in a real chat.

EMMA: They are right there for you. But what about the deep thoughts we keep quiet inside our heads?

JOSH: Yeah, what about those?

EMMA: That brings us to our next point, the inner voice.

JOSH: The inner voice. The little tiny person talking inside my head all day long.

EMMA: Yes, that little voice. It narrates your whole life. But right now, the quiet voice in your mind is speaking the wrong language.

JOSH: My inner voice is very chatty.

EMMA: Right.

JOSH: But you are right. It speaks my home language. It never speaks English unless I force it to.

EMMA: We need to change that habit.

JOSH: We want a bilingual inner voice.

EMMA: Bilingual?

JOSH: Yes. Bilingual means you can speak 2 languages well.

EMMA: Okay.

JOSH: So my inner voice needs to speak English too. But do I have to think in English all day long? That sounds tiring.

EMMA: No, start small. Do it in a safe space where there is no pressure at all.

JOSH: My head is a very safe space. If I make a mistake in my mind, nobody laughs at me. There is no judge.

EMMA: Exactly. And please do not just name boring things.

JOSH: What do you mean?

EMMA: Do not just look at your shoes and think, I am walking.

JOSH: I am walking.

EMMA: I am sitting. I am standing.

JOSH: Yes, that gets very dull very fast. I would be— get bored of my own mind.

EMMA: It is too dull. You need to have real thoughts and opinions.

JOSH: Opinions? Like saying what I truly like and what I hate?

EMMA: Yes. Let us say you see a guy wearing a very stylish jacket on the street.

JOSH: Oh, I love a good jacket. Maybe a sharp leather one for the winter.

EMMA: Do not just think, that is a nice jacket. Think something bigger. Think, Wow, that is nice, but I want it in a dark color.

JOSH: I see. You are having a real full thought. I want it in a dark color. It's a real view on the world.

EMMA: Yes. And you must connect it to strong feelings. English must become the voice of your real feelings, not just a test you take.

JOSH: This is huge. Many folks view English just like a school math test.

EMMA: They really do.

JOSH: It is just rules and grades on a page. It feels cold.

EMMA: But language is real life. If you are upset, let your inner voice be upset in English. Let it feel the pain.

JOSH: Like if I drop my hot toast on the dirty floor. I usually get mad in my home language.

EMMA: Try to be mad in English. Think, oh no, my nice breakfast is ruined. I am so mad right now.

JOSH: Or if I am full of joy, The sun is warm and I feel so great today.

EMMA: Connect the English words to the joy and the pain. Emotion makes the words stick in your mind like strong glue.

JOSH: If I feel it deeply, I will not forget it. The word becomes part of me.

EMMA: Exactly. Make the language a part of your real heart. But before we get to the scary stuff, let us take a short break.

JOSH: Sounds good to me.

EMMA: We are taking a quick mid-talk beat. We have a question for you. Please leave us a comment.

JOSH: Yes, drop a comment below. We want you to finish a sentence for us. Tell us about a time you froze up.

EMMA: Share the exact moment your brain just stopped working in the chat. Where were you? Who were you with?

JOSH: It is not a test. We just want to share the pain together. I will read your comments and smile with you, not at you. We've all been there.

EMMA: We really have. Also, please take one short second to subscribe to our channel.

JOSH: Just a soft tap on the button. It helps us keep making these fun talks for you every week.

EMMA: Thank you so much. Now let us move to the next part, Out Loud and Alone.

JOSH: Out Loud and Alone. This sounds a little scary to me.

EMMA: I know it does. There is a deep fear of making a mistake. You worry about sounding silly in front of other people.

JOSH: Oh, for sure. When I try to speak, I feel like everyone is judging my slow words. My face turns red. I want to hide.

EMMA: We all get shy. But you have to get in the cold water to learn how to swim. You cannot learn to swim by reading a dry book.

JOSH: You really cannot.

EMMA: You really— you will sink to the bottom.

JOSH: You have to splash around and get wet.

EMMA: Right. So you must build the muscle for real chats by speaking out loud when no one is watching you.

JOSH: So I do it alone?

EMMA: In your room with the door fully shut.

JOSH: Yes.

EMMA: A great way to do this is called shadowing.

JOSH: Shadowing? Like a dark shadow on the ground on a sunny day? It just follows you around?

EMMA: Exactly. You find a native speaker on a video. You listen to them speak and you follow them closely. You echo their rhythm.

JOSH: Am I just acting? If I copy them like a parrot, am I really thinking? It feels like a fake trick.

EMMA: It is not fake. You are borrowing their rhythm. You teach your mouth the physical dance steps of the language.

JOSH: Oh, so I train my jaw and tongue to move in the right ways?

EMMA: Yes. Your brain learns the music of the speech. Then later on, your own real words will flow to that same music.

JOSH: That makes a lot of sense. I can pretend to be a movie star in my room.

EMMA: You can. Another great trick is to record yourself.

JOSH: Oh no, I hate hearing my own voice on a tape. I sound so weird and squeaky.

EMMA: We all hate it. But it is vital for growth. Talk into your phone for just 2 minutes, then play it back.

JOSH: 2 minutes is not so bad. But what am I listening for? Every single tiny mistake I made?

EMMA: No. If you look for every error, you will feel lost and sad. Pick exactly 3 small things to fix. Just 3.

JOSH: Okay. Only 3. That is a safe number. Maybe one word I said wrong or a long pause I want to cut out.

EMMA: Yes. Fix those 3 small things and try again. It is a very safe way to grow.

JOSH: What else can I do alone to build this speaking muscle?

EMMA: You can narrate your life out loud. Let us say you are making a cheese and tomato sandwich in your kitchen.

JOSH: My favorite lunch.

EMMA: A nice thick slice of cheese on fresh bread. Talk out loud while you make it. Say, I am taking the bread. Now I cut the red tomato. This tomato is very juicy.

JOSH: It is like I am the star host of a busy cooking show. Now I add the cheese to the top.

EMMA: Yes, you narrate every step out loud, like a life story. Where else could you do this?

JOSH: In the shower. I sing in the shower anyway. I could just talk about the soap and the hot water.

EMMA: The shower is a perfect place. It trains your brain to speak on the fly with no script.

JOSH: So I am building the muscle in secret. Then I will be very strong when I go outside to talk to real folks.

EMMA: Exactly. But what do you do when you are with someone outside? And your brain just stops working.

JOSH: That is the worst.

EMMA: That takes us to the freeze.

JOSH: The freeze.

EMMA: The absolute worst feeling in the whole world.

JOSH: Yes.

EMMA: It is that sudden panic when your mind goes blank in a real chat. You have no words left to give.

JOSH: It is like the power going out in a dark house. Someone turns off the light and I cannot find the door to get out.

EMMA: That is a great way to show it. Anxiety blocks the brain. When When you are scared, the words run and hide.

JOSH: Hide under the bed. So what can we do when the lights go out and panic hits?

EMMA: First, use filler phrases. A filler phrase is a small group of words that buys you time.

JOSH: Buys me time? Like paying cash to buy a few more seconds on a clock?

EMMA: Huh. Not cash. It is a slip of the tongue to keep the air full of sound. It gives your brain a moment to catch up.

JOSH: So what is a good filler phrase I can use today?

EMMA: You can just say, let me think about that.

JOSH: Let me think about that. Oh, I like that. That sounds very smart and calm.

EMMA: It does. Or you can say, that is a good point. Give me a second.

JOSH: While I say that out loud, my brain is working hard in the back room to find the real answer.

EMMA: Yes, exactly. The panic drops because you are speaking. Now, the second trick for the freeze: you must make your big thoughts simple.

JOSH: Make them simple? What do you mean by that? Are my thoughts too big?

EMMA: Often we freeze because we try to say a huge, complex thought all at once.

JOSH: Give me an example of a huge thought.

EMMA: Like trying to choose between studying for a degree in pure math or taking a hard job in a big firm.

JOSH: That is a massive thought. I would choke on those words. I would not know how to say all of that fast.

EMMA: Right. So do not try to use fancy words. Do not give up and stay quiet. Break a huge thought into small, easy pieces.

JOSH: How do I make that massive thought into a small piece? Show me the trick.

EMMA: Just say, Should I study more or get a job?

JOSH: Should I study more or get a job? Wow. That is so clean and clear.

EMMA: Yes. The lesson is clear. Do not trap yourself with big words. Tell the basic truth in simple terms.

JOSH: I had a freeze like this last week. I tried to tell my friend about a very deep, sad movie I watched.

EMMA: What happened?

JOSH: I got lost in the complex plot. I froze. I should have just said, it is a sad film about a man and his dog.

EMMA: Yes. Simple is always better. It keeps the chat moving. The other person still gets the main point.

JOSH: They get the exact point. But what happens when you do all this hard work and you still feel stuck?

EMMA: This leads us to our final big point. Held back.

JOSH: Held back. This is the flat patch we teased in the opening, right?

EMMA: Yes, it is. It is the weird step nobody expects. You do all the hard work, but you feel like your English has stopped growing.

JOSH: It is a terrible feeling. I study every single day, but I feel like I'm walking on a flat, dusty road that never ends.

EMMA: That is the plateau. A plateau is a high, flat piece of land. You are not climbing a hill anymore. You are just flat.

JOSH: It makes me want to quit. It takes a huge emotional toll. I think, why try so hard? I am not getting any better.

EMMA: But you are getting better. You just cannot see the growth yet. Let us set some real timelines so you know what to expect.

JOSH: Okay. Give me the raw facts. How long does this flat road last?

EMMA: If you practice well, you will see small changes in 2 to 3 weeks.

JOSH: 2 to 3 weeks? That's not so bad. I can hold on for a few weeks.

EMMA: But for the English to feel truly natural in your mouth, that takes about 6 full months.

JOSH: 6 months. That is a very long, flat road to walk without seeing a big change.

EMMA: It is long. But keep this weird fact in mind: during the flat days, your brain is still building secret roads behind the scenes.

JOSH: Building secret roads? Like a hidden crew of workers inside my head in the dark?

EMMA: Huh. Yes, they are laying down the fresh dirt and the hard stone. You just cannot drive your car on the road yet.

JOSH: So the hard work is going on deep down. Even if I cannot see the finished road today?

EMMA: Yes. The brain is forming links. So the lesson here is to trust the slow process. Be kind to yourself.

JOSH: It is hard to be kind to myself. I get so mad when I make a basic mistake after months of study.

EMMA: Do not be mad. Your brain is tired from building roads. You must celebrate the small wins.

JOSH: Small wins. What does a small win look like in real life?

EMMA: Like sitting on your sofa, watching a movie, and knowing a joke without looking at the text on the screen. Oh,

JOSH: I love that feeling when the actor tells a joke and I laugh at the exact same time as the native speakers.

EMMA: Yes, that is a huge win. It means the secret roads in your brain are finally open for traffic.

JOSH: So, I just need to keep walking on the flat patch. The big climb will start again soon.

EMMA: It will start again. Just keep moving forward. Do not quit on the flat road.

JOSH: I will keep walking. This gives me a lot of hope.

EMMA: I am so glad. Let us look back at all the tools we talked about today.

JOSH: Sounds good.

EMMA: It is time for a quick recap. Let us count the main points out loud.

JOSH: I am ready.

EMMA: Point 1: The round trip takes way too long. Cut it down and take words off the shelf by finding new ways to swap them.

JOSH: Point 1 is all about staying in the English zone and finding many paths to one simple idea.

EMMA: Point 2: Train your inner voice to use English for real feelings. Then speak out loud, alone, to build the strong muscle.

JOSH: Point 2 is my favorite.

EMMA: Be the star of your own sandwich cooking show in the kitchen. Point 3: Use simple filler phrases to buy time when you freeze, and break big thoughts down to beat the long flat patch.

JOSH: Point 3 reminds me to be kind to myself and trust the slow secret roads in my mind.

EMMA: Those are the core steps to success. Now let us wind things down with Vocab Unwind.

JOSH: Oh, my favorite part of the talk. I am ready.

EMMA: We have 6 words today. Word number 1 is translate. Repeat after me. Translate.

JOSH: Translate.

EMMA: To translate is to change a word from your home language into English.

JOSH: I want to stop having to translate every single thought in my head before I speak.

EMMA: Yes, and when you do stop, you will speak so much faster.

JOSH: I cannot wait for that.

EMMA: Word number 2 is shelf. Repeat after me. Shelf.

JOSH: Shelf.

EMMA: A shelf is a flat wooden board where you store books or items on a wall.

JOSH: My mental shelf is full of English words, but some are just too high to reach right now.

EMMA: They are too high today, but the daily swaps will bring them lower.

JOSH: I will work on that.

EMMA: Word number 3 is voice. Repeat after me. Voice.

JOSH: Voice.

EMMA: A voice is the loud sound you make when you speak, or the silent sound inside your mind.

JOSH: My inner voice is getting very good at English now. It loves to complain about the cold rain.

EMMA: That is a great start. And if you stop trying to translate, your voice will sound even more clear.

JOSH: Good point. No more tiring round trips for my brain.

EMMA: Word number 4 is echo. Repeat after me. Echo.

JOSH: Echo.

EMMA: An echo is when you copy a sound right after you hear it spoken.

JOSH: I try to echo the cool actors in my favorite shows to learn their fast rhythm.

EMMA: That is a great way to practice.

JOSH: It is very fun to do.

EMMA: Word number 5 is freeze. Repeat after me. Freeze.

JOSH: Freeze.

EMMA: To freeze is to stop moving or thinking when you feel very scared or lost.

JOSH: When I freeze in a chat, I just say, let me think about that, to buy some safe time.

EMMA: Excellent. And keep bringing those new words down from the high shelf.

JOSH: I will wipe down that dusty board every single day.

EMMA: Word number 6 is win. Repeat after me. Win.

JOSH: Win.

EMMA: A win is a happy success, even if it is a very small step forward.

JOSH: Laughing at a funny film joke is a great small win for me.

EMMA: It sure is. And speaking with no freeze is another huge win to aim for.

JOSH: I echo that thought for sure. Winning feels so good after a long flat road.

EMMA: Well, that brings us to the end of our episode today.

JOSH: It went by so fast.

EMMA: It really did. So keep the big picture in mind. Stop the long round trip. Practice alone, out loud, and trust the slow flat patch.

JOSH: Be kind to your brain. It is working very hard to build those hidden roads for you.

EMMA: Thank you so much for spending your free time with us today. We know your time is precious.

JOSH: We really value you being here.

EMMA: It is a pure joy to help you learn and grow.

JOSH: Take care of your family.

EMMA: And keep your English cozy.

JOSH: Before you go, please hit the subscribe button. One tap costs nothing at all, but it keeps these episodes coming to you. It is just a tiny tap on your screen, but it is a huge help to us. We love making these talks for you.

EMMA: We really do love it. We hope you will come back and join us for the next chat.

JOSH: See you next time, everyone. Keep chasing those small wins.

EMMA: Goodbye. But as you go, ask yourself this. What is one secret English road your brain is building right now that you will only truly see tomorrow?

Vocab Unwind

6 key words and phrases from this episode

#	WORD	MEANING	ANALOGY	EXAMPLE
1	**translate**	To change a word from your home language into English.	Carrying every word across a bridge before you can use it.	*I want to stop having to translate every single thought in my head before I speak.*
2	**shelf**	A flat wooden board where you store books or items on a wall.	A high kitchen shelf you cannot reach without a stool.	*My mental shelf is full of English words, but some are just too high to reach right now.*
3	**voice**	The loud sound you make when you speak, or the silent sound inside your mind.	A radio in the room that never fully switches off.	*My inner voice is getting very good at English now. It loves to complain about the cold rain.*
4	**echo**	When you copy a sound right after you hear it spoken.	Shouting into a canyon and hearing it back.	*I try to echo the cool actors in my favorite shows to learn their fast rhythm.*
5	**freeze**	To stop moving or thinking when you feel very scared or lost.	A film that pauses on one frame.	*When I freeze in a chat, I just say, let me think about that, to buy some safe time.*
6	**win**	A happy success, even if it is a very small step forward.	One small tick on a long list.	*Laughing at a funny film joke is a great small win for me.*